

II Text Study Circle

A seated session built on assigned chevrotah study, group discussion, and role-play: every commandment gets a voice.

AUDIENCE

Teens (middle school and up). Adults joining as participants can use the same questions as written.

GROUP SIZE

Works most easily at four to twenty-four, and shines with smaller groups. Adaptable outside that range; see the note before Materials.

ROOM

Any seated arrangement works: a circle of chairs, couches, or around tables. No wall space needed.

STAFFING

One facilitator. For more than about fifteen participants, add a circulating staff member or assistant to keep chevrotah pairs on topic.

Why This Session Exists

By the end, a participant should be able to name at least two Jewish values from the document and apply each to a real situation from their own online life, take a position on a dilemma and give a reason for it, and name one thing in the document they disagree with or find missing.

Two values discussed well beats ten values mentioned. The timings and group sizes here are guidance, not requirements. If a choice you make in the room serves that standard better than this sheet does, follow the room. Full objectives and enduring understandings are at the front of the Study Guide.

ADAPTING TO YOUR GROUP

Fewer than four: study as a single group with yourself as a chevrotah partner, and take two commandments rather than assigning all ten.

More than twenty-four: give the same commandment to two or three pairs, then have those pairs compare readings before the full-group share. Duplication is a feature here, not a problem.

If time gets short: shorten the chevrotah, not the full-group conversation. In a camp setting especially, the plenary is where the value lands, and pairs will reach their ceiling sooner than you expect. A facilitator at one of our pilots cut chevrotah time to protect the group discussion and reported the group discussion still was not long enough.

Materials

- ☐ Camper handouts, one per person or per pair (the chevrotah questions are on the last page)
- ☐ Scenario cards, cut apart
- ☐ Pens and participant feedback slips (60 and 90 minute versions)

Timing

This program can be adapted based on time available.

Segment	45 min	60 min	90 min
1. Welcome and opening ritual	5	5	10
2. Chevrutah study (assigned)	15	20	25
3. Large-group discussion	10	15	20
4. Scenario role-plays	15	15	25
5. Research moment	–	5	5
6. Closing and feedback	–	–	5
Total	45	60	90

Pick your column and follow it top to bottom; each column adds up on its own. Segments 5 and 6 are fully written out below, so nothing new is needed to run the longer versions.

Running the Session

1. Welcome and Opening Ritual (5/5/10 min)

Welcome everyone and name what this is: a set of ten commandments for how we treat each other online, built from Jewish values and from research on what teens actually experience. Then open with the teaching that anchors the whole project:

SUGGESTED OPENING

דֶּרֶךְ אֶרֶץ קְדֻמָּה לַתּוֹרָה, *Derech eretz kadmah laTorah*: basic human decency comes before Torah itself (*Vayikra Rabbah* 9:3). Invite a moment of quiet for each person to consider what "decency" means in the places they spend time online. Then ask two or three people to share a word or phrase that came to mind.

Let them know this document is a living draft: their reactions and pushback today will shape the next version. That is not a disclaimer; it is an invitation.

2. Chevrotah Study (Assigned) (15/20/25 min)

Pair everyone up (friends pairing up is fine; a few groups of three is fine), then assign each pair one or two commandments. Assignment is what makes this format thorough: across the room, every commandment gets studied, and the group hears all ten in the share-back.

ASSIGNING WITH FEWER THAN TEN PAIRS

Give each pair two commandments, or cover what you can and present the rest yourself in one sentence each during the discussion. With exactly ten pairs, it is one each. Assign by handing each pair a numbered slip or just counting off around the circle.

Each pair reads its commandment together from the handout and works through the questions on the last page of the handout:

Chevrotah Questions

1. Read your commandment aloud together, including the Jewish value and the "What Teens Are Saying" section.
2. Does this feel realistic for people your age? Why or why not?
3. Where have you seen this play out, online or in person?
4. What would you add, change, or push back on?
5. Choose one idea or takeaway to share with the group.

IF A PAIR FINISHES EARLY OR DRIFTS OFF TOPIC

Give them a second commandment with one question: "Do your two commandments ever conflict with each other?" (For example, Seek Truth and Guard Your Tongue: when might honesty and restraint pull in opposite directions?) A quiet staff presence nearby keeps conversations real.

3. Large-Group Discussion (10/15/20 min)

Go around the circle: each pair shares its commandment and one takeaway. Keep this moving; the goal is that everyone hears all ten, not that every pair gives a report. Then open the conversation with whichever of these

prompts fits your group:

Discussion Prompts

- Which commandment would be hardest for you to follow? Which would be easiest? Why?
- Are any of the commandments in tension with each other? When might two of them pull in opposite directions?
- Where do you draw the line between AI helping you learn and AI doing the learning for you?
- Is there a commandment missing? What online behavior or Jewish value would you add?
- Research says teens are becoming more critical of social media. Does that match your experience?

4. Scenario Role-Plays (15/15/25 min)

Break into small groups of three to five. There are ten scenario cards, so keep it to ten groups or fewer; if your group is large enough to need more, two groups can work the same scenario. Each group receives one scenario card and prepares two things: which commandments apply, and a short role-play of a constructive response, meaning what a mensch would actually do or say in that moment. Groups perform for each other, and after each performance, ask the room: "What did they get right? What else could work?"

DEPTH OVER COVERAGE

You will not use all ten cards, and you should not try. One scenario that catches fire is worth more than five read in a rush. If a group's performance sparks a real conversation, stay in it and let the remaining groups hold their cards for another day.

IF ROLE-PLAY IS A HARD SELL

Some groups love performing and some freeze. The fallback is the read-aloud version: a volunteer reads the card, offers their own answer first, then opens it to the room. Same cards, same questions, no stage fright.

5. Research Moment (–/5/5 min)

Take five minutes to mention the research and impact of these technologies. Participants consistently want to know more about what all this is doing to them, so tell them, and tell them where it comes from:

SUGGESTED SCRIPT

"Every commandment you studied today has a section called What Teens Are Saying. Those are not decorations; they are real studies of thousands of teens. A couple worth knowing: almost half of teens say social media has a negative impact on people their age, and teens themselves draw a line with AI: most say using it for research is fine, but fewer than one in five say the same about having it write your essay. The research is in your hands in this handout. Take it seriously; it is about you."

6. Closing and Feedback (–/–/5 min)

Hand out participant feedback slips and give everyone three quiet minutes to fill them out. Collect them before anyone leaves; slips that go home do not come back. Close with:

"In a place where there are no human beings, strive to be a human being." (*Pirkei Avot* 2:5) Online is often a place where it feels like there are no human beings. Strive to be one.

In the 45 and 60 minute versions, skip the written feedback for participants and instead fill out the facilitator feedback form yourself as soon as possible after the session, while it is fresh.

Facilitation Notes

- **Assignment is the feature.** Assigning commandments, rather than letting pairs choose, is what guarantees the whole document gets heard. Hold to it.
- **Keep the share-back brisk.** One takeaway per pair. The discussion prompts are where the depth happens.
- **Do not fear the lull.** If a prompt lands flat, move to the next one. Two prompts that generate real talk beat five that get polite answers.
- **Adults in the room.** If adults participate alongside teens, they use the same questions and answer for themselves, not about "kids these days."